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PAOLINI DIDN'T EVEN HAVE THE PROVERBIAL 'PUNCHER'S CHANCE' FOR AN UPSET

Iga Swiatek maintained her **dominance on clay** at Roland Garros, while Carlos Alcaraz further solidified his status as Rafael Nadal's heir apparent.



confided, "Honestly, I don't know why I didn't believe in myself."

Alas, against Swiatek, Paolini didn't even have the proverbial 'puncher's chance' for an upset. Unlike highly athletic and versatile Karolina Muchova, who extended Swiatek to 6-2, 5-7, 6-4 in the thrilling final a year ago, the undersized Italian lacked the weapons.

Not even Jasmine's best shot, an aggressive, topspin forehand, matched up against Iga's forehand, the most devastating shot in women's tennis since the booming serve of Serena Williams.

The most glaring disparity was first serve speed where Swiatek increased her average from 102 mph last year to 111 mph this season. In

sharp contrast, Paolini averaged just 95 mph at Roland Garros.

The final started with a bang. Intense and focused, Swiatek pumped her fist after smacking a backhand passing shot for 30-15. She held serve for 1-0. Looking surprisingly calm for the biggest match of her life, Paolini raced to a 40-0 lead.

When Swiatek responded with four straight points, including three forehand winners, to earn a break point at 40-Ad, former World No. 1 and NBC analyst John McEnroe said, "This is about as good as Paolini can play, so it would be discouraging if she lost this game."

The hustling Italian hung on to hold serve and then broke serve for



Coming into her own: 2024 has been a breakthrough year for Paolini, winning the WTA 1000 title in Dubai and reaching the fourth round and final of the Australian Open and the French Open, respectively. *AFP*

a stunning 2-1 lead. The crowd chanted "Iga! Iga!" and she responded like a champion. With her wicked Western forehand bounding high over the diminutive Paolini's strike zone, Swiatek seized seven straight points, breaking serve and holding her own serve.